of the underlying theology that informed such institutions. In a nutshell, my intention is to demonstrate that the 1858 Proclamation of religious neutrality by Queen Victoria provided an optically convenient veneer to the evangelical and civilising tendencies of the colonial administration, evident from their conduct as well as their own discussions in both international fora and in the British Parliament.

For instance, this petition moved by the Bishop of Oxford on behalf of the residents of Ham in the House of Lords on 6 July 1860 demonstrates the clear intentions to fully Christianise education in India by introducing the study of the Bible in government schools across the country[12]:

> The Bishop of Oxford *presented a Petition from Inhabitants of Ham, praying that the Holy Scriptures may not be excluded by Authority from the Government Schools in India*. He said he did not intend to enter at length upon the great question to which the petition referred. Their Lordships had recently had an opportunity of hearing all that could be said upon the subject stated ably, completely, and temperately by the noble Duke on the cross-benches (the Duke of Marlborough), and he felt it would be improper for him to attempt to repeat the arguments and statements which had been already submitted to the House. He was, however, anxious, in the first place, to do away with an impression which might probably prevail in the public mind from the mode in which the discussion on a previous evening had terminated. It might appear to the country that the noble Duke (the Duke of Marlborough) stood alone in that House in the opinions which he had expressed. Now, that was very far from being the case. He (the Bishop of Oxford) had been ready and desirous of stating how entirely he concurred in the sentiments expressed by the noble Duke, but the mode in which the discussion terminated prevented his doing so. He was also anxious to suggest two grave considerations to the Government in connection with the subject. *He had laid upon the table fifty petitions from various parts of the country with the same prayer as that of the petition he now held in his hand, that the Bible might be introduced into the schools in India; but he was fully persuaded they were not a tithe of the petitions which would pour in upon both Houses of Parliament upon this grave subject, and he would venture to predict that in a matter like this, upon which the religious mind of the people*